

CHAPTER 1: GO IN. GET OUT BY MIDNIGHT OR DIE.

“Your life is about to change forever,” Hrod warned the twenty year old girl who stood beside him in a field as the sun crested the horizon. “Are you sure you want to do this? Becoming a war mage is no small thing.”

The girl did not look like a frail maiden. She was strong and tall, but her face was so innocent with light brown hair gently curling around it. She looked around the field at all the people gathered, glanced at the arch, and tried not to look at the barrier mist dividing the human and fairy realms, then answered, “I’m sure.”

Hrod put his hand on her shoulder. “Catria, you’ve been like a sister to me for years. I don’t want to see you hurt fighting in the arena.”

“But I can help,” Catria insisted. “We need a healer on the team, and it’s rare any man gets healing as a power on his soul quest. Plus, I need to become a war mage or my father will lose his province. He is a good ruler of it, but you know he had to retire as a war mage.”

“I know,” Hrod responded. “I wish I could have protected him. I was in the battle he was wounded in. I just still worry about you becoming a war mage. You saw what happened to your father, and you know at times war mages do die.”

“I’ve been training,” Catria defended. “I can do it. I have to. Rhys wants me on the team. He’s been encouraging me.”

“You are good,” Hrod assured her. “I just want you safe. You know I’m protective of you. Are you sure about this?”

“Yes,” Catria answered. “You know my father’s province will go to whoever replaces him as a war mage. He loves the people of his province. He’s a good leader. I’m going to make sure he keeps it.”

“You are so selfless,” Hrod responded. “Just be careful. I can protect you in battle, but I can’t go with you on the soul quest, and you are the only one going from Terrian this time. Be careful. Soul quests are dangerous. Not everyone who goes in comes out alive.”

Rhys, the other seven war mages from Terrian, and Catria’s father and mother all walked up to her.

“Are you ready?” Rhys asked. “It’s time to go.”

Catria took a deep breath to calm herself. She hugged her father and mother, hoping nothing would go wrong, and she’d survive the soul quest so it wouldn’t be the last time she saw them.

She knew she was supposed to go with the team, but she ran over to where her siblings were playing with friends and gave them quick hugs. They were excited for her, and her youngest sister, who was only four, ask for her to bring back a unicorn horn for her.

“That might hurt a unicorn,” Catria explained. “And no one sees unicorns.”

“But they are real,” her sister insisted. “I want to go see fairies. Tell me what they look like.”

“I will if I see them,” Catria assure her.

“Come!” Rhys called.

Catria gave her sister a last quick hug and then ran over to the team.

Everyone on the team gave her advice, which really was very overwhelming.

They didn’t stop until York stood up by the arch and called out, “Everyone, attention!”

Everyone turned to York. He had just been put over the arena, so people didn’t know him well, but the rules to the arena were set and to be abided by, so whoever was over it didn’t really matter much.

“Welcome, everyone!” York called to the crowd. “Today is this year’s day for soul quest. Each team is sending enough contestants to fill their team out to the maximum of ten.”

Catria looked over at the team from Aschelle. They had more people going.

Other people seemed to be noticing that too, so York explained, “Aschelle has extra people going on soul quests. I want to make sure rules are followed strictly, so I need people who can bring in war mages who break rules and have the power to punish those who shed blood outside the arena. So, Aschelle is going to have a war mage team as usual, and a lesser war mage team, who will enact justice as needed to keep the war mages in control.”

Catria tensed. Something about that just hit her wrong. Yet, she turned her attention back to York.

He continued, “Everyone should be well-versed with soul quest, but I will make sure everyone clearly understands. Everyone should know the mist around the forest is magical, and keeps the fae on that side and us on this one. Once a year, we may send people through the portal. You will all be safe from any fae as long as you don’t attack and as long as you get out by midnight.

“Do gremlins really come out at midnight and attack?” Catria whispered to Hrod.

“Yes,” he answered. “They do. Get out by midnight. I won’t be there to help you.”

Catria instinctively put her hand on her sword and whispered again, “Fae can’t attack, but normal animals can, right?”

“Yes,” Hrod confirmed. “We trained you to fight them for a reason.” Again, he put his hand on her shoulder. “You don’t have to do this.”

Catria looked over at her father, who now walked with a limp. “I have to,” she corrected, setting her resolve.

York continued, “Every potential war mage is to go through the portal. You should have your metal you are bringing in with you. You will choose a plant, eat a leaf and bring a leaf, stick, or bark back. You will bring something back from an animal, and you will need to find a gem. What you choose will determine the power you get. Once you are out, your teams will take you to forge your weapons in the fairy fire at the arena. Does everyone understand?”

The people gathered all nodded. York had said nothing of the soul quests that was not clearly known.

“You know what you want?” Hrod asked Catria.

“Yes,” she answered. “I wish you could come with me.”

“Only those going on soul quests are allowed to go through the arch,” Hrod reminded her. “If I went through, it would be a death penalty for me. It could be for you too. I’m not sure how strict York will be. You can do this.”

“I hope so,” Catria responded as she threw her arms around him.

“You can do this,” he assured her. “Watch out for wild animals and for rogue contestants who try to kill you.”

Catria stiffened. She’d been warned many times that

others trying to become war mages might try to kill opponents. No, it wasn't a competition, but particularly Aschelle and Phyrn wanted to weaken the other teams, and if their war mage contestants didn't succeed, it meant they didn't have ten war mages for the year.

The rules explicitly forbid sabotaging anyone, but she's been warned that it happened anyway. People just were careful that nothing could be proved.

York then announced, "It's time to enter."

Catria gave a final hug to her parents and teammates and walked up to the arch. This was it. Once she went through, there was no turning back. She'd become a war mage, or die trying.